

Asking Better Questions

Get a useful answer the first time, instead of a vague one you keep having to fix.

You are here

By the end of this guide you'll be able to:

Diagnose a bad answer in one glance, and know which of four things was missing.

Say who it's for — the single biggest change you can make.

Describe what "good" looks like without using words like *good*.

Get options instead of answers, so you stop having to be right first time.

Steer a near-miss into the thing you wanted, in about four seconds.

Write your own version of any request, using four questions and a piece of paper.

If you've read *Claude for Absolute Beginners*, two of these lessons will be familiar. There they got a page each. Here they get the room they actually need, with twelve worked examples.

01

The answer was boring because the question was

Everyone has the same first disappointment. You type something reasonable, you get back something that reads like a form letter, and you conclude this has been oversold.

Look at what happened, though. You asked a question that could have come from anyone, about a situation you didn't describe, for a person you didn't mention, wanting an outcome you didn't state. You got the average of every possible answer. That is exactly what you asked for.

This is good news. It means the quality of what comes back is under your control, and the controls are all ordinary English.

Here's the diagnosis, and you can run it in one glance. When an answer disappoints, one of four things was missing:

Who it's for. It wrote for nobody in particular, so it wrote for everybody.

What you actually wanted. You asked for help *with* something rather than asking for a specific thing.

What good looks like. No length, no tone, no shape — so it guessed, and guessed long.

What only you know. The circumstances that change the answer entirely.

The next four lessons are those four things, one each.

Try this now. Find an answer you were disappointed by. Work out which of the four was missing. It's usually obvious once you're looking for it.

02

Say who it's for

The largest single improvement available, and it costs about six words.

Writing changes completely depending on who's going to read it. You already know this — you don't text your sister the way you email your accountant. But when we type a request, we routinely leave the reader out, and then wonder why what comes back has no particular voice.

Naming the reader gives it a target. Not a description of the reader — the reader.

WITHOUT A READER

Write a message explaining I'll be late.

WITH A READER

Write a message to my boss explaining I'll be an hour late. We get on well and she's relaxed, but she's chairing something at ten and needs to know now.

The second names who's reading, what they're like, and why the timing matters. What comes back is short, warm and useful. The first is a form letter.

Try this now. Take any request you'd normally write and add six words naming the reader. Nothing else. Compare.

03

Say what you actually want

The second most common gap, and the easiest to fix once you notice it.

Most people ask for *help with* something. "Help me with an email." "Can you help with my CV." It's polite, and it's how we'd open with a person — but a person would then ask what kind of help. Here, you'll simply get whatever seemed most likely.

Ask for the thing, not for help with the thing.

Not *help me with this letter* but write, shorten, explain, compare, check, list, rewrite, summarise, plan, quiz me.

VAGUE VERB

Can you help me with this contract?

SPECIFIC VERB

Explain what this contract obliges me to do, in plain English, and list anything that looks unusual.

The second one has two clear jobs. You can tell whether it did them. The first can't be judged at all.

Try this now. Rewrite a request so it starts with a verb.

04

Say what good looks like

You know what a good answer looks like. It doesn't. Words like *good*, *professional*, *engaging* and *nice* carry almost nothing — ask ten people what "professional" means and you'll get ten answers.

Replace the judgement word with what it would actually take to satisfy you. Usually that's three things: how long, what tone, what shape.

How long. *Under a hundred words. Three sentences. One page.* This alone fixes most disappointment, because the default is long.

What tone. *Warm but brief. Formal. Like I'm texting a friend. Plain, no enthusiasm.*

What shape. *A numbered list. A table comparing them. Only the subject lines. Three options, no explanation.*

THE STRONGEST MOVE IN THE WHOLE BOOK

Show it an example. Paste in something you wrote and liked, and say *match this voice*. One real example teaches it more about how you sound than three paragraphs of description ever will.

Try this now. Add a length and a tone to a request you've already made. Watch it tighten.

05

Tell it the things only you know

It knows nothing about your life. Not your job, your family, your town, your history with the person you're writing to, or what happened last Tuesday. Not because it's being careful — it genuinely has no idea, every time you begin.

Everything that makes your situation *yours* has to come from you. That's not a limitation to work around. It's the whole job.

The useful part is knowing what's relevant, because "more context" doesn't mean everything.

The relationship. Close, distant, awkward, professional, strained.

The history. What's already happened, what's been tried, what was said last time.

The constraint. Money, timing, a policy, something you can't say.

The outcome. What you want to be true afterwards.

WRITE IT ONCE

Most of your context repeats. Keep four or five sentences about yourself in a note on your phone — what you do, who you deal with, how you like to sound. Paste it in when it's relevant. Every answer improves at once.

Try this now. Write those five sentences. It's the highest-return ten minutes in this book.

06

Ask for three, not one

A quiet trick that removes most of the pressure.

When you ask for one thing, you have to have described it correctly, because you're going to get exactly one attempt at what you asked for. When you ask for three, you get a range — and choosing between three real options is far easier than imagining the right one in advance.

Three versions also tells you something. If all three miss in the same direction, your request was the problem. If one is close, you've found your starting point.

ONE SHOT

Write a thank-you note for a wedding present.

THREE TO CHOOSE FROM

Give me three versions of a thank-you note for a wedding present — one warm and chatty, one short and sincere, one slightly funny. My aunt gave us a set of knives we genuinely like.

You'll pick one in four seconds, and often take a line from another.

Try this now. Ask for three of something, deliberately different from each other.

07

Nudge it, don't start over

The biggest time-waster is throwing away a near-miss and rewriting the whole request. Don't. The conversation is still open, and it remembers everything you've said.

Two or three small corrections beat one perfect opening request, almost every time. Each takes about four seconds.

THE PHRASES THAT DO THE MOST WORK

Shorter — half that. · Longer, with a specific example. · Warmer. · More formal. · That's too salesy. · Keep the second paragraph, redo the rest. · Give me three versions. · Now make it an email. · Say that like I've never done this before. · That's not quite what I meant — I actually need...

It's the difference between briefing a photographer and firing one. You don't start again after the first shot. You say *good — now step left, and try it brighter.*

You: *Write a note to my neighbour about their tree overhanging my garden.* **It:** a polite, stiff, four-paragraph letter. **You:** *Too formal. We're friendly, we chat over the fence.* **It:** warmer, shorter, more natural. **You:** *Good. Cut the last line, it's passive-aggressive.* **It:** the version you send.

Forty seconds, three nudges. You'd have spent longer staring at a blank page.

Try this now. Take anything and nudge it three times without rewriting your original request.

08

Let it ask you

The move for when you don't yet know what you want — which is more often than anyone admits.

Sometimes the reason a request comes out vague is that the thing in your head is vague. No amount of careful phrasing fixes that, because there's nothing precise to phrase yet.

So hand the problem back.

WHEN YOU CAN'T ARTICULATE IT

I'm trying to sort something out but I can't describe it clearly yet.
Ask me questions until we've worked out what I actually want,
then help.

This works because answering a specific question is far easier than composing a description from nothing. You'll say things in response to a question that you'd never have thought to write down.

Two more worth keeping:

FOR A DECISION

Ask me five questions that would help me think this through, then wait for my answers before saying anything.

FOR SOMETHING YOU'RE AVOIDING

I've been putting this off for two weeks. Ask me what's actually stopping me.

Try this now. Use the first one on something genuinely unresolved. Notice that you end up doing the thinking — which is the point.

The Ask Builder

Not a template. Four questions, answered on paper. **Your four answers, read out in order, are the message.**

1 — Who is this for? Name them and say what they're like. *My landlord, who I get on with but who ignores emails.*

2 — What do you want to happen? State the outcome, not the task. *I want the heating fixed this week without souring things.*

3 — How long, and what tone? *Under a hundred words. Polite but clearly not a first request.*

4 — What do you know that it doesn't? The facts only you have. *It's been five days, I've messaged twice, there's a toddler in the house.*

Read those four answers straight through and you have written this:

THE FOUR ANSWERS, IN ORDER

This is for my landlord, who I get on with but who ignores emails. I want the heating fixed this week without souring things. Keep it under a hundred words, polite but clearly not a first request. It's been five days, I've messaged twice, and there's a toddler in the house.

Nobody had to fill in a blank or learn a format. You answered four questions about your own life and the message assembled itself.

WHY PAPER

Answering out loud or on paper gets you past the blank-box freeze. The box asks you to compose. The four questions only ask you to answer.

Try this now. Run the builder on something real. Keep the page.

Twelve before-and-afters

The rest of this book is worked examples. Each shows a thin request, the same request done properly, and one line on what changed. Read them or skim them — they're here to be recognised, not studied.

BEFORE

Write an email to my son's teacher.

AFTER

Write an email to my son's Year 4 teacher. He's been coming home upset about maths and says he's the only one who doesn't get it. I'd like to ask what she's seeing in class and whether we should be doing something at home. Warm, not accusing, under 150 words.

What changed: who, what's happened, what I want, and the tone to avoid.

BEFORE

Complain about my broken dishwasher.

AFTER

Write a complaint to a retailer about a dishwasher that failed three weeks after delivery. They've already rescheduled the engineer twice. I want a replacement rather than another repair. Firm and factual, no threats, under 200 words.

What changed: the history, and the specific outcome I'm asking for.

BEFORE

Thank you note for a gift.

AFTER

Write a short thank-you note to my neighbour, who fed the cat for a fortnight while we were away and refused any money. She's practical and would find anything gushing embarrassing. Four or five sentences.

What changed: what they did, and what they'd hate.

BEFORE

Help me cancel plans.

AFTER

Help me cancel dinner with friends on Saturday. I'm exhausted rather than ill, and I don't want to invent an excuse. I'd like to be honest and still be invited next time. Two or three sentences.

What changed: the real reason, and the thing I'm worried about.

BEFORE

Ask for a refund.

AFTER

Write a message asking for a refund on a course I paid for and haven't started. It's eleven days past their ten-day refund window. I want to ask for an exception without sounding entitled. Short and polite.

What changed: the awkward detail I was tempted to leave out.

BEFORE

What can I make for dinner?

AFTER

I have chicken thighs, half a cauliflower, rice and the usual cupboard basics. I've got about half an hour and two people to feed, one of whom won't eat anything spicy. Give me three options.

What changed: what I actually have, how long I have, and who's eating.

BEFORE

Explain photosynthesis to a child.

AFTER

Explain photosynthesis to my seven-year-old, who asked me this morning and I realised I couldn't. Use something in a kitchen as the comparison. Then give me one question I can ask to check she's followed it.

What changed: the age, the kind of comparison, and what I want to do next.

BEFORE

Help me prepare for a difficult conversation.

AFTER

Help me prepare to tell my sister I can't keep lending her money. I love her and I don't want this to become the thing our relationship is about. Ask me questions first, then help me work out what to say.

What changed: the relationship, the fear, and asking it to question me first.

BEFORE

What does this letter mean?

AFTER

I'll paste in a letter from my energy supplier with the account number removed. Tell me what it's actually asking me to do, whether there's a deadline, and whether anything in it should concern me.

What changed: three specific questions instead of one open one.

BEFORE

Plan a trip to Edinburgh.

AFTER

Plan three days in Edinburgh in October for two people in their sixties who walk well but hate crowds and rushing. One booked thing per day, plenty of gaps, and somewhere unhurried to eat each evening.

What changed: who's going, when, and the pace they want.

BEFORE

Write a review.

AFTER

Write a four-star review of a small local restaurant. The food was genuinely excellent and the service was slow because they were clearly short-staffed. I want to be honest about the wait without putting anyone off going.

What changed: the tension in it — what I want to say and what I don't want to cause.

BEFORE

Make my CV better.

AFTER

I'll paste my CV. I'm applying for admin roles after eleven years out of work raising children, and I don't know how to handle the gap. Tell me what to change and how to describe those years honestly.

What changed: the actual worry, said out loud.

When it still doesn't work

"I gave it loads of context and it's still generic." Check you gave *relevant* context rather than lots of it. Four sentences about the relationship beat two paragraphs about your week.

"It keeps writing more than I want." Length is the instruction people most often forget. Say the number. It obeys.

"It sounds like it, not like me." Stop describing your voice and show it. Paste in something you wrote.

"I don't know what I want." Lesson 8. Let it ask you.

"It ignored part of what I asked." Long requests with several jobs get partly answered. Number them, or do one at a time.

If you only do one thing

Take one habit and leave the other seven.

Name the reader.

Six words, at the front of any request that produces writing. *Write a message to my landlord, who... An email to my son's teacher, who... A note to my neighbour, who...*

It's the smallest change in this book and the largest effect. It gives the answer a target, a tone and a reason to exist, and it takes less effort than reading this page did.

Everything else here is refinement on top of that one move.

Do this next

Not set up yet? → Your First Ten Minutes With Claude — six pages, free, one result you'd show someone.

Want the whole foundation? → Claude for Absolute Beginners — the account, the screen, and the ten habits that make it work.

Cautious about privacy or accuracy? → Is This Safe? — what it can and can't see, why it's sometimes wrong, and the short list of things never to type in.

Want ready-made ideas? → 101 Everyday Things to Ask Claude — a hundred and one complete sentences, open at any page.

The Everyday Claude Guides — start where you are.

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